

ECTLC

Recovery

Life Lessons

Lesson Plan: When the Structure Is Gone, Staying Connected to God and Community

Core thesis: Sobriety is not sustained by environment control. It is sustained by connection, confession, and immediate intervention.

Audience: ECTLC Adult participants (men and families) **Time:** 30 minutes

Materials: Whiteboard, pens, printed handout

Learning Objectives

- Understand why isolation often comes before relapse.
- Identify early relapse behaviors before substance use begins.
- Create a “First 24 Hour Response Plan.”
- Build a post-ECTLC connection strategy for Stability that is centered on God and community.

Key statement to repeat:

If you isolate, you deteriorate.

Section 1: The Myth of Strength

Teaching Point

Relapse rarely starts with a substance. It starts with disconnection.

Board Write

- **Emotional relapse**
- **Mental relapse**
- **Physical relapse**

Discussion Questions

- What changes first before someone uses?
- What does isolation look like at ECTLC?
- What does it look like outside of ECTLC?

Scripture Anchors

- James 5:16, confession and prayer with others
- Ecclesiastes 4:9-12, strength in partnership

Section 2: Why You Cannot Isolate at ECTLC and Why That Is Protection not Oppression

Many people experience structure as pressure. Reframe it as protection.

ECTLC Structure Provides

- Accountability
- Visibility, people can notice changes
- Immediate intervention, support is nearby
- Forced fellowship, you are around others
- Correction and coaching in real time

Group Exercise

Prompt 1: What protects you here that will not exist outside?

Examples: accountability, curfew, drug tests, mandatory classes, staff oversight, work therapy, restricted environments and time management.

Prompt 2: What replaces those protections when you leave?

Let silence work. The goal is honest realism, not fear.

Section 3: Early Relapse Behaviors

Important: Do not wait until you are in “physical relapse” to act. By then you are already losing the fight.

Emotional Relapse (Common Indicators)

- Irritability, anger, resentments
- Skipping prayer, avoiding Scripture, spiritual numbness
- Avoiding meetings, avoiding trusted people
- Complaining and blaming, “nothing works here”
- Overconfidence, “I got this”

Mental Relapse (Common Indicators)

- Bargaining, “just once” thinking
- Romanticizing the past
- Secret planning, covering tracks
- Minimizing consequences
- Reconnecting with old people, places, patterns
- Keep it simple, those within ECTLC that keep it simple, succeed. Don't make this simple program complex. Those within ECTLC that make it complex, struggle.
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Participant Exercise: My Top 3 Warning Signs

Write your personal early indicators. These are usually behaviors, moods, or choices, not “I used.”

Section 4: The First 24 Hour Response Plan

Principle: Delay increases danger. Secrecy accelerates relapse. Movement interrupts obsession.

Step	Action
1. Call within 10 minutes	I call: _____ (name) at _____ (phone)
2. Tell the truth completely	No minimizing. No hiding. “Here is exactly what is happening.”
3. Physically relocate	I move to a safe place: _____
4. Pray immediately	Simple surrender prayer: “God, I cannot do this alone. Help me right now.”
5. Remove access	I remove myself from triggers, money, transportation, contacts, or locations as needed.
6. Same-day meeting	I attend a meeting, group, or church support the same day.

Mini Script (What to Say on the Phone)

This helps when you feel ashamed and cannot find words.

“I need help right now. I am having relapse thoughts/behaviors. I am not safe alone. Can you talk with me and help me take the next right step?”

Section 5: What Happens When You Leave

When structure drops, exposure rises. Recovery does not fail because you got weaker. It fails because protections were not replaced.

ECTLC Protection

Replacement After Exit

Mandatory spiritual inputs	Consistent church involvement, daily prayer and Scripture plan
Built-in accountability	Sponsor/mentor and a weekly check-in schedule
Limited access to old patterns	Boundaries, blocked contacts, avoided locations, new routines
Community around you	Intentional fellowship, group attendance, service team
Work therapy and structured time	Purposeful employment, service commitments, schedule discipline

Section 6: Connection with God (Operational, Not Emotional)

Daily Connection Plan

- **Time:** _____
- **Place:** _____
- **Duration:** _____
- **Plan:** Scripture, prayer, inventory

Nightly Inventory (2 minutes)

- Where did I drift today?
- Who do I need to tell the truth to?
- What is one corrective action for tomorrow?

Section 7: Community Commitment

Group Commitment:

“I commit to never isolating in silence.”

My 3 People (Call List)

1) Name: _____

Phone: _____

2) Name: _____

Phone: _____

3) Name: _____

Phone: _____

Church or meeting location:

Leader Notes: Keep the tone direct and hopeful. Emphasize that asking for help is not failure, it is maturity.

HANDOUT

Take With You

Practical

My Exit Plan: Staying Free When I Leave ECTLC

Purpose: Replace ECTLC protections with intentional protections, so I do not drift into isolation and relapse.

Non-negotiable rule: I do not isolate in silence.
If I feel myself drifting, I act within **10 minutes**.

1) My “Protective Layers” (What Will Replace ECTLC Structure)

Layer	My Plan
God Connection	Daily time, daily prayer, daily Scripture plan, weekly church.
People	Sponsor/mentor, accountability partner, safe friends, service team.
Place	Stable housing, safe environment, no “old” hangouts.
Schedule	Planned mornings, planned evenings, limited idle time.
Boundaries	Blocked contacts, avoided locations, financial guardrails.

2) My Early Warning Signs (I Must Act Before I Use)

My Top 3 Warning Signs

My Usual Lie

The lie I tell myself right before drifting:

The truth I will speak instead:

3) My First 24 Hour Response Plan (When Relapse Behaviors Begin)

Step 1, Call within 10 minutes:

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Step 2, Tell the truth completely:

No minimizing. No hiding. "This is where I am at."

Step 3, Physically relocate:

Safe place: _____

Step 4, Pray immediately (simple prayer):

"God, I cannot do this alone. Help me right now. Put people around me. Give me the next right step."

Step 5, Remove access:

If needed: hand over money, leave the area, turn off phone, block a contact, ask someone to pick me up.

Step 6, Same-day meeting or support:

Where: _____ Time: _____

4) My Daily, Weekly, Monthly Operating Rhythm

This is about consistency, not perfection. Small daily obedience beats big emotional moments.

Daily (10 to 30 minutes)

- **Morning connection with God:** prayer and Scripture
- **One truth-telling moment:** check in with a person
- **One healthy action:** walk, work, service, fitness
- **Evening inventory:** where did I drift today?

My daily time: _____ AM and _____ PM

Weekly (Structure Replacement)

- **Church service:** 1 time per week minimum
- **Recovery meeting/group:** _____ times per week
- **Accountability check-in:** scheduled, not random
- **Service:** volunteer or serve in church/community

My weekly schedule: _____

Monthly (Inspection and Course Correction)

- **Review boundaries:** people, places, money, phone
- **Review my triggers:** what keeps showing up?
- **Update my call list:** make sure it is current
- **Set one growth goal:** spiritual, relational, vocational

My monthly review date:

Emergency Rule (If I Break My Plan)

- I do not disappear.
- I do not lie to protect my image.
- I immediately tell a safe person and ask for help.
- I return to basics for 72 hours: God, people, meetings, sleep.

5) My Boundaries (Write Them Down)

People I Will Not Contact

Places I Will Not Go

6) My Identity Statement

I am not “trying to stay sober.”

I am building a connected life with God and people, and I act fast when I drift.

Print tip: Save this as a PDF and print two copies, one for you, one for your accountability partner.